

TargetAI Go-To-Market Roadmap

Counselor-Led → Student-Activated → Platform Scale

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Executive Summary

This roadmap outlines a four-phase strategy to establish TargetAI as the trusted AI-powered platform for college counseling. The approach prioritizes building credibility with professional counselors before expanding to direct student and parent markets.

Key Strategic Principles

- **AI prepares. Counselors decide. Students grow.**
- **No AI essay writing** — maintaining academic integrity
- **No acceptance guarantees** — honest, ethical guidance
- **Student & counselor data ownership** — trust through transparency

Product Reality (Baseline)

Counselor View	Ready
Student View	Almost Ready
Essay Feature	Clustering & analysis only (non-generative)
Core Advantage	Trust-first, counselor-aligned AI workspace

Phase 1: Counselor Credibility Pilot (Months 0–2)

Objective: Build trust, validate product-market fit, refine messaging

Target Audience: Independent counselors, small counseling firms

Deliverables

1. Counselor dashboard with full feature set
2. Essay clustering and positioning tools
3. AI-powered meeting summaries
4. Ethics commitment documentation

Guardrails

- No public student signup
- No student-facing pricing
- No advertising or public marketing

Go-To-Market

- Founder-led outreach to 10–20 carefully selected counselors
- Private demos and hands-on onboarding
- **Timing consideration:** Target summer months (May–August) when counselors have bandwidth

Success Metrics

- Counselor NPS ≥ 8
- Strong organic referrals within counselor networks
- Qualitative feedback validating positioning language

Phase 2: Firm Distribution (Months 2–4)

Objective: Scale usage through established counseling firms

Target Audience: Counseling firms with existing student rosters

Deliverables

1. Counselor View + private Student View
2. Firm administration dashboard
3. Per-student pricing model
4. **Recommended:** Tiered firm packages alongside per-student options for predictable costs

Guardrails

- No public signup available
- No direct student billing—all through firms

Go-To-Market

- Formal firm partnership agreements
- Referral programs leveraging Phase 1 advocates

Success Metrics

- Active students per firm (target: 50+ per partner)
- Renewal intent $\geq 80\%$

Phase 3: Student Activation (Months 4–6)

Objective: Drive direct student engagement within firm ecosystem

Target Audience: Students enrolled through counseling firms

Deliverables

1. Student dashboard with personalized insights
2. Essay clustering visualization
3. Task management and application timelines

Go-To-Market

- Counselor-initiated student invitations
- Student-to-student referral program

Success Metrics

- Weekly active rate $\geq 60\%$
- Time-to-first-value < 10 minutes

Phase 4: Direct Student & Parent Growth (Month 6+)

Objective: Platform expansion to consumer market

Target Audience: Parents and students outside existing firm relationships

Deliverables

1. Public signup flow
2. **Consumer pricing:** \$49–\$99/month or \$299–\$499 annually (with launch discount option)
3. Counselor marketplace connecting families to professionals

Pricing Strategy Note

Parents routinely spend hundreds on test prep and thousands on private counseling. A higher anchor price preserves future pricing power while positioning the product appropriately in the market. Consider a "founding member" or "early access" discount rather than establishing a low baseline price.

Go-To-Market

- Content marketing targeting anxious parents
- Referral incentives for existing users
- School counselor allies and partnerships

Success Metrics

- Paid conversion rate $\geq 5\%$
- 12-month retention $\geq 70\%$

Strategic Recommendations

Roadmap Strengths

- **Counselor-first approach:** College counseling is trust-dependent. Building credibility with gatekeepers before going D2C avoids the mistake of trying to disintermediate professionals who could be your best distribution channel.
- **Ethical differentiation:** The "no AI essay writing" stance positions TargetAI as trustworthy in an increasingly skeptical market.
- **Phased expansion:** Reduces risk by validating each stage before investing in the next.

Areas for Consideration

- **Phase 1 timing:** Two months may be tight for achieving NPS ≥ 8 with enough counselors. Account for admissions seasonality—summer is ideal for onboarding.
- **Competitive response:** If successful, larger players (CollegeVine, Collegeadvisor.com, Naviance) may copy features. Your moat is the counselor relationship and ethical positioning—reinforce this consistently.
- **Content/community angle:** Consider building an audience on platforms where anxious parents gather (Reddit, Facebook groups, X) before Phase 4 to accelerate direct growth.

Missing Elements to Address

1. **School Counselor Strategy:** Mentioned in Phase 4 but could be valuable earlier. A free tier for under-resourced public school counselors builds goodwill and creates referral pipelines.

- 2. **Competitive Intelligence:** Document key differentiators vs. specific competitors to guide sales conversations.
- 3. **Risk Mitigation:** Define contingency plans if Phase 1 NPS targets aren't met or if firm adoption is slower than expected.

Summary Timeline

Phase	Timeline	Focus	Key Metric
1. Credibility Pilot	Months 0–2	Trust & validation	NPS ≥ 8
2. Firm Distribution	Months 2–4	Scale through partners	Renewal ≥ 80%
3. Student Activation	Months 4–6	Engagement	WAR ≥ 60%
4. Direct Growth	Month 6+	Consumer expansion	Conversion ≥ 5%

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